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Ahmad Alotbi/Gulf News

UAE STRUCK BY HEAVY RAIN, THUNDERSTORMS

■ The UAE experienced unstable weather yesterday as the Al Bashayer low-pressure system brought torrential rain, hail and tornado-like conditions across multiple emirates, forcing authorities to mobilise emergency teams and issue urgent safety warnings. With forecasters predicting continued adverse weather today, Dubai Government employees were directed to work remotely while employers in the private sector firms across the country were urged to implement stringent workplace safety measures. Ras Al Khaimah bore the brunt of yesterday morning's fury as a powerful hailstorm accompanied by damaging winds struck the emirate shortly after dawn.

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UAE's excise tax law puts health in focus

REGULATIONS TO LINK TAX TO SUGAR LEVELS, STREAMLINE PROCEDURES

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The Ministry of Finance has announced a new Cabinet resolution that updates key parts of the executive regulations governing excise tax in the UAE. The changes are aimed at modernising the system and making it more precise and health-focused.

One of the most notable shifts is how excise tax is applied. The tax is no longer based on a simple flat rate. Instead, it now follows a tiered structure, particularly for sweetened drinks. Products with higher sugar content will face higher excise tax, while those with lower sugar levels will be taxed at reduced rates.

The updated rules also strengthen reporting requirements and introduce clearer laboratory testing standards to verify product ingredients. The Ministry said these measures are designed to improve accuracy, reduce disputes, and ensure better enforcement of the tax.

Exemptions

Certain health-related products are exempt under the revised framework. These include items used to help people stop smoking, reflecting a stronger public health focus within the excise tax system.

According to the Ministry, the changes are intended to align the

WHAT'S EXCISE TAX?

In the UAE, excise tax is a tax on goods harmful to health or the environment, like tobacco (100%), energy drinks (100%), and sugary sodas (50%).

Starting January 1, 2026, this changes to a tiered system where the tax amount is based specifically on the grams of sugar per 100ml — punishing higher sugar content with higher tax rates.

executive regulations more closely with the updated law. Key areas affected include tax registration, excise tax deductions, and refund requests. The resolution also improves several procedural elements within the existing regulations.

The Ministry of Finance said the updates aim to make compliance easier for businesses, improve clarity around tax obligations, and support a stable business environment. Officials added that the amendments will help strengthen tax compliance, protect public revenues, and support the development of a more efficient and flexible tax system.

The Ministry noted that the changes form part of a broader effort to align the UAE's tax framework with international best practices, enhancing transparency and efficiency in the application of excise tax nationwide.

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